Gandhi. ‘I would be very happy to do that, but my party is a national party and won’t allow me to just focus on one state.’ Matter closed.

My second question was a little more controversial. Was it true that the Congress party was waiting for Rahul to take over as prime minister, and Dr Manmohan Singh as prime minister was a bit like Bharat in the Ramayana doing a holding job for Ram? The question was perhaps framed rather crudely or was considered inappropriate. Either way, it touched a raw nerve. ‘I resent that, Mr Sardesai!’ was the terse, angry response. ‘The prime minister is doing a fine job and a question like this only belittles Dr Singh in a manner that I find unacceptable.’ I had been suitably admonished. For the next hour, Mr Gandhi took other questions and lectured us on how UP was caught in caste and community politics, and how he could have easily lived abroad but had chosen instead to serve the people of the country—almost it appears out of a sense of noblesse oblige. I silently ate my idlis.

When the session was over, some of us asked if we could carry quotes from the interaction on the channels. I had already mentally conjured up a headline: Rahul wants to be chief ministerial candidate for Uttar Pradesh but his party won’t let him! But we were all in for a severe disappointment. Just as we were all drafting headlines and working out the pitch, bang came the spoiler. ‘Sorry, this is all off the record, I don’t want any controversy in the middle of an election,’ we were commanded by the Gandhi scion. My 2.30 a.m. flight with the bleary-eyed Gulf-bound breadwinners had been in vain.

So why had a galaxy of editors been summoned in the first place? The answer came from an old Congress source. Apparently, Mr Gandhi had found the ground was slowly slipping away from the Congress in UP. Yes, his rallies had attracted sizeable crowds, the television cameras had focused on him, but the votes, not surprisingly, seemed to be going elsewhere. The enthusiasm of the previous summer when Mr Gandhi had led a farmer agitation had given way to the harsh realities of a UP winter where it was becoming increasingly obvious that the SP was in pole position to gain from the anger against the Mayawati government. The meet-the-press was designed almost as an anticipatory bail application. Mr Gandhi wanted to